been the work of a Jain, on account of its promotion of vegetarianism and its abhorrence of animal sacrifice. It has even been argued that Thiruvalluvar, author of *Thirukkural*, could have been a Jain.[18]

Given this Jain dominance in early Tamil literature it is entirely reasonable to suppose that it was the Jain monks whose presence kick-started the early Tamil civilisation known as the Sangam Age by presiding over regular literary assemblies held in Madurai, even if the first of these is unlikely to have taken place before the start of the second century BCE. To my mind, these Sangams must have been very like the bardic festivals of poetry, music, singing and dance known as eisteddfods ('sessions') that have been a feature of Welsh culture for many centuries – and which themselves have also been subject to a great deal of fanciful nationalistic embellishment.

A quite remarkable characteristic of this early Tamil literary creativity is the absence of all-powerful deities. Instead of the gods it is the local rulers who are showered with praise as patrons of the arts of peace and war. What survives from the very earliest phase divides into two groups: the Pathupattu ('Ten Idylls') and the Ettuthogai ('Eight Anthologies'). One of those sets of anthologies – and the most revealing from a historian's point of view – is the *Purananuru*, or 'Four hundred poems about the exterior', the word *puram* ('exterior') referring to public as opposed to domestic life. Its four hundred poems are addressed to more than fifty named Chola, Chera and Pandya kings, as well as eighty-three lesser kings. The chief concern of their authors is to enumerate a particular ruler's virtues: his greatness, his generosity as a patron and his prowess as a warrior. So patently, the king was the fulcrum around which much of ancient Tamil society revolved, imposing order out of chaos, keeping enemies at bay and even bringing the rains to water the fields and keep them fertile. But what I find so